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Teen And Up Audiences

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Part 1 of Of Wing and Claw side stories

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by Paganaidd

Summary

Ariel remembered standing in the dirt, shocked at the almost comical image before her: the sorcerer's leather shoes, smoking and charred in front of her. Her gaze flicked between them and the sorcerer's body, ten feet away.

The crew chief and his assistants were tasked with bringing her back to the Fright Zone. They stopped for the night at one of the Horde border waystations.

And there, Ariel finds unexpected help.

- Inspired by Defiance by TheNotebookWizard

Horde Border Waystation
Secure holding

Two years before Princess C'yara's abduction

The pain of the lightning still tingled along Ariel's nerves, different from the bruises and the lashing. Different from her swollen eye and cut lip. A bone-deep ache like from working on the metal pipes on cold mornings.

The girl huddled, knees to chest, trying to conserve her heat while over and over, the whole mess played out in her mind. The lightning arcing through her, lighting up her world with white-hot agony.

But then something *happened*. Somehow she had seen the power in her mind's eye and known what to do. Like diverting water into a ditch. Like a flood through a pipe. She raised her hands and all that white power went back where it came from.

Right into the sorcerer's stupid smug face.

She remembered standing in the dirt, shocked at the almost comical image before her: the sorcerer's leather shoes, smoking and charred in front of her. Her gaze flicked between them and the sorcerer's body, ten feet away.

Was he dead? She thought he was breathing, but she didn't know. Fuck, if he was dead, so was she.

Sick and dizzy with the magic, she almost didn't feel them grab her as her knees buckled underneath her and she went down.

They'd beaten her, not so much as punishment, but so she wouldn't be a problem as they dragged her back to the Fright Zone. She spent the rest of the day trussed up in the back of a skiff. Her chin itching where her cut lip bled and one eye swollen shut. The pain in her side was from when they kicked her in the ribs.

They were taking her to the Dark Temple. That thought chilled her more than the damp dirt she sat on.

The crew chief and his assistants had been tasked with bringing her back to the Fright Zone. They had stopped for the night at one of the Horde border waystations.

Lucky for her, they locked her up in what looked like an old barn, in a little room that they said was warded against magic by the black symbols painted inside it. It meant that she didn't have to spend the night tied to a tree. The room was cold, but at least it was dry.

Unfortunately, it had a proper lock on the door.

Footsteps thumped around overhead. One set banged downstairs.

Summoning the will to get up, Ariel levered herself up from lying on the floor to sitting. The movement made her see stars.

A man came in through the outer door and then unlocked the inner.

"Come get your food." He put a tray down. "I ain't fool enough to come over there."

He stepped back and locked the barred door, watching through narrowed eyes as she limped across the dirt floor.

"Don't see why they're bothering to feed you," he growled. As he spoke, he pointed toward each corner of the ceiling and shook his head.

Following where he pointed she saw what he meant. No cameras.

She nodded slowly. Was he trying to reassure her or threaten her?

He touched his forefinger to his lips, pointed at her and made a little explosion sign with his two hands.

She sighed and nodded. What else could she do? Not like denying it would help.

He pointed to himself, then put his fist on his flat palm and pushed upward.

I'll help you.

He pulled a piece of paper from his pocket. Three triangles and a sideways oval above them. He pointed to the wall behind Ariel as though she should understand.

She didn't.

He rolled his eyes and shook his head then shoved the paper back into his pocket. "*Back later,"* he signed.

Then he stomped upstairs.

The water in the bottle on the tray didn't smell like the brackish swampwater they filtered through their ancient purifiers. It was clear and cold with a ghost of a scent that made her think of snow. But even the icicles had the same gritty flavor as the air. Not like this.

Where had they gotten it?

The plate had brown ration bars and a bowl of steaming liquid. It smelled good, with little bits floating in it.

She dipped a finger in and tasted it carefully.

Oh. Oh, stars.

She'd never had anything like it. Salty, tasting like the small birds folks occasionally caught and roasted on a stick.

And the slabs on her plate weren't ration bars, but bread! Ariel had tasted bread twice in her life and never seen it like this, hot and soft.

The food warmed her right through. Warmed her enough that she managed to doze for a few hours under the thin blanket she found in the corner.

"Psst." In the darkest part of the night a sound woke her and a hand touched hers in the pitch black.

"Hey! Don't hit!" The hand grabbed Ariel's wrist as she defensively punched. "Quiet." A calloused hand shot out, going over her mouth. "You'll bring everyone down on us. I'm trying to fucking help you."

"What do you want?" Ariel demanded in a whispered shout when the hand came hesitantly away from her mouth.

"I'm not going to let Shadow Fucking Weaver train a new sorceress." The voice was quiet and lethal. "Especially one that's already strong enough to mess up a sorcerer already."

"What? Why?"

"Shut up and listen. Can you walk out of here on your own feet? Or did they break your legs?"

"I can walk. I think my ribs are cracked, but I can stand and walk."

"Whew. Okay, we can work with this." He sounded relieved.

"What? What are you talking about?"

"If these were regular troops, I wouldn't do this, but these guys are just a construction crew." He took a deep breath. "Underneath the floor is a cellar. You're going to hide in it."

A long pause.

"Unless you *want* to go to the Dark Temple?"

"Fuck no!" she hissed.

"All right. If you do exactly what I say, I can get you out of this." The hand pulled hers toward them and put it down on the lip of an open space in the floor. "Sorry, I don't dare get a light. The hatch is here. Feel this."

The edge felt like dirt packed onto plywood. Was the dirt floor fake?

"Hope you're not scared of the dark. Turn around onto your belly. Put your feet down. Feel the ladder. Yeah?"

She did as he told her, inhaling sharply as it jarred her ribs. She reached through the void with one foot and was relieved to feel a solid wooden step. Cautiously she climbed down until she felt the dirt floor at the bottom.

The blanket tumbled down beside her.

"I'm gonna lock you in. You gotta be absolutely quiet until they leave, right? They're going to search the whole place. This cellar's never been found. If they do find you? Well, you're on your own. Everyone knows sorcerers have ways to find hidden things. There's some water bottles and a bucket, if you need it."

The sound of dirt burying the door sounded like the dirt on top of her grave.

In the dark, she groped around until she found a shelf full of jars. The little space was three paces long by two paces wide. Ariel found the promised water bottles. She also used the bucket.

Nothing else to do now but go back to sleep.

Hidden cellar
Horde Border Waystation

Two years before Princess C'yara's abduction

Panicked voices muffled by the dirt woke her. How long had it been?

There was some kind of ventilation in the cellar, she could feel a breeze on her face. Tiny holes in the wall let in pinpricks of daylight.

"Where the fuck is she? I thought this room was supposed to be magic proof?" That was the voice of the crew chief.

"I dunno. That's what they told us those black symbols were for."

Ariel crouched in the dark listening to the men talking softly, her heart in her throat. She couldn't see anything and she didn't recognize any of the voices except for the crew chief.

"Lost her? Well, damn." The floorboards creaked under the weight of a heavy body. "That probably won't go great for you when you get back." That voice seemed confident. In charge.

"Yeah, no shit." The crew chief sounded ready to cry. "I thought you said she'd be secure here."

"I told you we had a secure room. I do not have the soldiers to put a watch on every piece of cargo that comes through here. If she was that valuable you should've put a watch on her."

"What? We're not soldiers!" The panic was sinking in if the way his breath hitched meant anything. "It's not going to go great for you, either."

"Yeah… I'll probably have some inspector or another come and look over my shoulders for the next six months or so," the confident voice agreed. "That would not be good for business."

Shit, shit, shit. They were going to give her up.

“Y’know, Boss,” a new voice began, tentatively. “We got some sand bags. And some rocks.”

The boss sounded almost… contemplative. “And, y’know, Carlo, it ain’t your fault you don’t know your own strength.”

“Ayep,” the new voice, probably Carlo, agreed.

“It’d be a damn shame if the girl were stupid enough to try to jump you when all you were doin’ was trying to bring her a meal.”

“Guess I hit her too hard.” Carlo again. “Sorry, Boss.”

“Didn’t she just fry one of yours?” The boss’s voice was sharp, as though he was taking reports and making plans..

“Not one of mine, Commandant.” The crew chief hawked and spat. “One of those bastard sorcerers.” The chief didn’t sound upset. Even overseers hated the sorcerers.

“Yeah. She killed a sorcerer. I mean…”

The boss let the words trail off. Let her deed sink in, before he continued. His were the light, deliberate footsteps; she could hear his voice moving as they paced back and forth.

“That proves she's dangerous. So, maybe I came out here to check on her. Maybe I even tried to get friendly and I needed to use my sidearm because she got cute with the magic.”

“Good thing you had it with you. You can't be too careful,” Carlo added. He must be big, the floorboards creaked even when he stood still.

“Look, if anyone hears… “ That was the crew chief.

“They won’t.” The Commandant was clearly unbothered. “If we walk out of here and say there was a scuffle.”

Footsteps back and forth as someone nervously paced.

"Nobody cares about a dead sorceress. Dr Halliday will sign off on it."

"He will?"

"Doc knows where his rations come from. We'll bring the box down here, fill it full of rocks, nail the coffin shut like the manuals say to do and bury it in the cemetery."

"But, what if the girl…?"

"What? Comes back?" A barked laugh. "She's in the Whispering Woods, getting herself eaten by something even as we speak."

"Yeah. No one comes out of there," Carlo's voice chimed in.

"I don't want to deal with the investigation they'll send out. I told you, it's bad for business."

Another one of those long agonizing pauses, then: "Yeah. And as long as she's accounted for, no one could say she escaped on my watch… " The crew chief spoke slowly, Ariel could imagine him nodding along.

This way…" The sound of two hands clapped together. "Everybody wins!"

A sidearm discharged and Ariel clapped her hand over her mouth to keep from crying out.

"Go get Dr. Halliday!" The commandant shouted. "I had to kill the little bitch and now I've got the fucking paperwork to do."

"Shame about that," he went on more quietly. "Didn't even make it to the Temple. That happens sometimes."

"Damn shame," Carlo put in loudly.

“I don’t know what is with the kids. In my day… “ Footsteps receded and Ariel didn’t hear what else he said.

Hours passed; over Ariel’s head, the three or maybe four sets of feet came and went. So many conversations that she couldn’t keep track.

Finally, she heard pounding, a hammer against wood.

“Yeah, nail it shut.” A new voice said. “Careful there. Sorcerer’s bodies can still be dangerous. Who the fuck knows if she’s booby trapped. Force Captain wants her in the ground before the end of the day.”

“Okay, Doc.”

“Okay, folks, on three. One, two, up!”

The room upstairs was quiet. More hours passed.

She paced for a while, worried. Maybe they *weren’t* planning on coming back for her. She opened one of the screw top jars and found that it smelled delicious. Some sort of fruit in a sweet juice. She drained the jar of juice and ate the soft flesh of the fruit.

At some point she settled down again with her back against the wall. She’d done time in the cooler before. Usually they didn’t bother to feed or water you if you were only going to be in there for a day. She was probably here for a long haul.

“Hey?”

The whisper brought her out of sleep again.

“You still alive?” It was the voice that had talked about nailing the coffin shut.

“Yeah! Yeah.” Ariel scrambled up the ladder. To her utter relief, nothing impeded her and the moonlight in the cell seemed almost intolerably bright after so long in the dark.

“Okay, they left this afternoon. Sorry, I didn’t want anyone to see me come in here. You’re officially dead as far as the Horde knows and you best get out of here.”

The man was tall, but Ariel couldn’t see anything else about him in the dim light.

“Here’s another water bottle. Head towards the mountains, like on the diagram. That takes you into the Woods. Got it?”

“Diagram?”

“You’ll see what I mean.” The door to the cell was open and he gestured toward it. “Just fucking go. Okay?”

A moment’s more hesitation. Was this a game? Was she about to get shot in the back?

Fuck it.

She ran up the stairs, bolted out of the side door and emerged into the clean night air.

Moons rose over the mountains as Ariel tried to figure out which way she was supposed to go. Then she saw it. Three almost perfectly triangular peaks with a flat, oval cloud above it.

They weren't kidding. You really could not miss it.

For a moment, Ariel stood frozen in the yard of the abandoned barn, her senses reeling. The world felt vast and terrifyingly silent after the cramped dark. The chill night air bit through her thin clothes and bare feet.

Officially dead.

The words echoed in her skull, a bizarre and fragile gift. The crew chief and his men had fabricated her death, sealed it with a box of rocks and a coroner's lie. She was a ghost now. A ghost with no shoes, broken ribs, and apparently sorcerer's magic.

She still didn't know what she'd done.

It didn't matter. She'd figure it out once she got the hell out of here.

The mountains rose up behind the treeline. Ahead was the Whispering Woods. That was where they were sending her.

One last glance behind her, and then she took off running, wrapping one arm around herself. Each jarring step shot agony through her ribs, but the trees were so close. Surely, she could make it to the shadows of the trees before her strength gave out.

Somewhere in the Whispering Woods

Two years before Princess C'yara's abduction

The next morning she woke drenched in freezing dew. Fortunately the trees *had* been close and she got there before the pain in her side made running impossible. After that, she walked until she stumbled and lay down where she fell.

The people in the waystation had pointed her this way for a reason. Either she'd find someone to help her, or else they were sending her to the cannibal clans that everyone said lived in the Woods.

That was still better than the Dark Temple.

For the first part of the day, the trees were thin enough to see the mountains. By the afternoon the Woods grew dense, the canopy closing in over her head. Underfoot, the thin path, barely there to

begin with, seemed to fade into the moss. When she stopped to get her bearings, she saw several paths and the mountains completely hidden from view.

Hunger squeezed at Ariel's belly as she kept walking, wondering what she should do. She'd never been alone like this.

People talked about edible plants, but people poisoned themselves too. She had no idea how to tell the difference. At least she found a couple running streams and was able to fill the water bottle she brought with her. She hoped she wasn't going to get the polka dot plague or whatever, but she wasn't going to be too picky. Especially as this was the best tasting water she'd ever had. Her bare feet were scratched and sore, but no worse than at the end of any other rough day.

By the time it started to get dark, Ariel had not seen the mountains for some hours. She had no idea if she was still heading in the right direction.

Throughout the afternoon, the forest had been utterly quiet. Now though, as the light slanted towards evening, she heard crunching and scuffling from the underbrush. Long shadows gathered under the trees, making the darkness feel like it was reaching out to her.

On nights like this, when they were near the Woods, the overseer would send them to collect wood and they'd have a bonfire to drive off any predators. Ariel wished she had some sort of firestarter.

She had magic. Magic started fires. What if she built a fire and then tried her magic? It couldn't possibly make anything worse, right?

Before it got dark, Ariel had collected wood and kindling, piling it in a convenient spot in a grassy clearing.

As she searched for wood, she tried to remember what had happened when she turned the lightning back. She didn't know, it

was just instinctive, like she was catching something and throwing it back.

Crouched by the cold campfire, she imagined being warm.

Her mind drifted. What was it that created and sustained fire? Fire was locked in the wood. It needed heat to set it off, a spark. And it needed air, like a living thing. And not just air, a particular component of air.

As though she were remembering something she learned years ago, she thought of the necessary ingredients to fire.

Fuel, oxygen, heat.

It had been a long walk and she was glad to sit, half dozing. For as long as she could remember, her own imagination was her surest sanctuary.

And in that sanctuary, ideas took shape.

In her mind she saw long chains of orbs. And then other orbs that orbited each other two-by-two. Almost like the games the little kids might play. And like a kid's game, the orbs began to change partners. Each time the partners changed, something happened, the space between the orbs glowed.

What was important were the spaces between. That was where the fire hid.

The glow moved faster and she understood how she'd done it; the way she'd moved the lightning.

The orbs were the pieces of the world. The current between them was heat, light.

Power.

That glow *knew* her. It answered her. It became sparks. Sparks became embers.

They fell onto dry, fluffy grass. The wind blew. The embers caught and leapt upward.

Heat on her hands. Light behind her eyes. The crackling. The roar.

Flames.

“Whoa!” Ariel jumped back, heart pounding, instantly on her feet.

The fire she had imagined had become real. It caught the dry grass and licked up to engulf the larger pieces. In two seconds it devoured the fuel she’d offered it.

The shifting lights made the shadows more sinister somehow, but maybe the trees liked the fire. They seemed to bend over her, their branches rubbing together like so many gnarled old hands.

Cautiously she moved back towards it, but the heat was too much. Perhaps she’d thrown too much wood on it?

A cracking sound. A burning coal spat onto the grass. A new fire sprang up spreading out. beyond the pile of sticks. Hungry, it reached the brush, encircling her. Flames jumped from the grass to the tree branches, some of the leaves catching, encircling her.

Oh. Oh, this was bad.

She’d heard of wildfires, how they would sweep across the Arid Plains, destroying everything in their path. How did it work in the Whispering Woods?

A hot wind blew from the flames, making her sweat. Black ash, smoldering at the edges, floated in the air as she turned around, looking for an escape route.

There was none.

Hands over her face she dropped back to her crouch, heat beating at her face, her clothes, her hair. This was the last thing she would ever know. This heat, the black choking smoke, and the…

Silence.

The thick smell of smoke gave way to a soft breeze. Cool, smelling of water and green things.

Pressing her hands hard against her face, Ariel refused to look. Whatever had just happened was clearly impossible. And even if it was possible, it couldn't be *good.*

Even as one part of her gabbled histrionically, another part of her marveled that she was still alive at all.

That didn't make her anymore likely to emerge from her defensive huddle.

"Hello?" A woman's voice, kind and far too close, made the girl jerk her head up.

Black haired and dark eyed, the woman crouched in front of her. Beautiful. Like something out of a dream, dressed in robes made of some flowing gossamer fabric. A strange diadem rested on her forehead.

Probably the most beautiful woman Ariel had ever seen.

Her expression was openly curious, and a smile graced her lips when Ariel met her eyes. "Are you all right?"

"What!?"

"Are you hurt, dear?"

"No. No, I'm…" Ariel couldn't say she was fine exactly, but, "I'm mostly okay."

The woman's eyes narrowed slightly, like she recognized the dodge. "Mostly?"

"I, uh. I mean…"

“No, let’s not do this here.” The woman glanced around fire damaged clearing, then back to Ariel. “Even if you aren’t burned, you’ve probably swallowed a lot of smoke. I think it would be a good idea if I had a healer look at you.”

Healer? What did she mean by that? A doctor? Ariel had never been hurt enough to see a doctor. She would rather bleed out, given what she’d heard.

“Are you alone out here?”

The woman had paused as though waiting for her to reply and it took Ariel a minute to process that she’d been asked a question.

“Yes, ma'am.”

The woman didn’t seem to like that answer, given the quick downturn of her mouth. Her eyes raked over her and latched onto the slave collar on Ariel’s neck. “Are you running from the Horde?”

Slowly, Ariel nodded, not seeing any point in lying.

“My name’s Castaspella, and I’d like to take you to Mystacor.”

“Mystacor?” Ariel gasped. She’d heard that name. That was where the most lethal of the combat sorcerers came from.

The woman frowned, and Ariel flinched and braced herself.

Instead of giving her a slap for speaking out of turn, the woman's face softened. “I'm sure you've heard terrible things about it.” A gentle humor lay under the words.

She stood, holding out her hand. “It’s where I live. I can take you there and give you a chance to recover. Then, I can take you wherever you want to go.”

Ariel stared at the hand Castaspella extended, almost too confused for fear.

“The fire?” she asked.

“Don’t worry. I put it out.”

Nodding in a jerky, uncertain motion, Ariel reached out, deciding it didn’t matter where she went.

The woman’s hand was warm. Solid.

“This part will feel odd, if you’ve never done this before.”

The world dissolved in a shimmer of light.

A heartbeat later, it reformed into a small, enclosed room filled with golden lamplight. The sound felt muted, distant. Books lined the walls, stacked on every surface. The air was still. Warm. It smelled of paper, old wood, and something green. Quiet in a way Ariel had never experienced.

Her chest hitched. Then her breath came faster. Too fast. Every inhale seemed shallower than the last even as she gulped into her lungs.

“Hey. Slow down.” Castaspella stepped close again, both hands gentle on Ariel’s shoulders.

But Ariel couldn’t slow down. The room blurred. Her ribs spasmed.

Oh, it *hurt!*

A high, keening sound built around her. It took her a moment to realize she was the one making it.

Two hands on her shoulders flexed and stroked her arms. “Look at me. You’re okay.” Those dark eyes captured hers. “Breathe through your nose.”

“I-I-I…” Ariel didn’t know what she was trying to say. How was this okay? The world just turned itself inside out!

“Take a moment. You’re safe.”

Safe? She was a slave. Ariel wasn’t sure she had ever been safe. But, breathing through her nose helped her feel less dizzy.

“Jerick!” The woman called. “Would you put on some tea? We have a guest.”

“Yes, Your Grace.” The voice came from the air. Probably a hidden comm speaker.

Your Grace. That meant something. It sounded like a title. Like “Force Captain” or “Chief.”

This woman had a title? Why was she talking to Ariel?

“What’s happening?” Ariel whispered, grabbing the woman’s wrists to steady herself.

The woman smiled and tilted her head. “A question. Wonderful.” She seemed sincere, like she really did welcome the question. “What’s happening is that the wards on the border of the Woods activated when you lit your fire. I brought you here because with all the smoke you inhaled I would prefer to keep an eye on you. Are you injured at all?”

Injured? Was she? A cut lip and some bruises and the ache in her side from being kicked, but it wasn’t like she was injured for real. And woodsmoke wasn’t nearly as bad as the Fright Zone smog.

“N-no, ma’am.”

“You must be tired. And I imagine you’d like to clean up?”

Looking down at herself, Ariel realized she was simply filthy, her feet muddy and her clothes covered with soot.

Embarrassed, she pulled her hands away and muttered, “That would be great.”

“Of course.” The woman pursed her lips. “What if we run you a bath? I’m sure that would make you more comfortable.”

It was kind of chilly for a bath, but she knew the woman was right. Infections were a lot worse than a cold wash.

“Come along, we can put you in one of the guest rooms.” The woman (the sorceress?) let go of her shoulders and beckoned her to follow.

The hallway was so strange that Ariel couldn’t name half the things she saw. The floor was wood? But polished to an almost glass-like shine, and warm under her feet. The wall had strange squares on the bottom half of the wall. Ariel couldn’t imagine what that was for. Pictures hung on the upper part.

They came into a room with thick pieces of cloth over the shiny floor. A desk made of that polished wood was in one corner. This didn’t look like a shower, but before Ariel could ask, the woman went through another door.

“I’ll just start the water.”

Oh, there was another room. That made sense. So, this was a bunk room? Only one bed, but it was big enough for three or four people. Six, if they were her size and they squeezed. It was off the floor, so there wouldn’t be cold drafts. That would be nice.

The sound of a lot of water running drowned out the woman’s voice, but she was still talking. Ariel followed her through the door. The room was close and humid, an enormous tub was filling with water that came out of a faucet in the wall.

The woman was pulling some white cloth from a cupboard. “Have you eaten recently?”

Recently? What did she mean by that? “Yes, ma’am. Um, Your Grace. Last night.”

“Last. Night.”

Shit! Was that the wrong answer? Ariel back-pedalled. "I mean…"

"Never mind." The woman shook her head. "I'll have something brought up while you're in the bath. Is there anything in particular you like?"

"Ah. Gray ones?" They almost never got gray ones, and everybody agreed those were the best.

"Gray..?"

"Ration bars."

"I'll see what they can do."

Ariel nodded.

"I put towels out on the sink."

The towels in question were strange; thick with fluffy fibers instead of just loose weave cloth. She could maybe scrub off instead of getting in the cold water.

Her Grace bit her lip, worried about something. The woman turned the tap and the water turned off. She eyed Ariel and then said, "I'm not sure if you're accustomed to this type of bath. You'll want to get in and soak."

Inwardly, Ariel sighed. So much for trying to get away without a cold dip. But it made sense given how filthy she was.

"If you toss your clothes in the hamper there, I can have them cleaned."

"I don't have anything else." Ariel looked down, picking at her stained trousers. They probably wouldn't make it through a wash without falling to pieces.

"I'll bring you something new to change into. All right?"

The woman probably wouldn't want to chance Ariel getting the place grubby with her dirty clothes. A large mirror was over the sink, Ariel's reflection was so covered in soot that her red hair was a muddy brown.

"Yes, ma'am. Thank you."

"I'll be back with clothes and tea."

Bowing to necessity, she stripped off her clothes and braced herself for the chill.

An involuntary cry burst from her throat when she put her foot in.

The water was *hot.*

"Are you all right?" Her Grace called from the other room.

"I-I'm… It's hot. Is that… Is it supposed to be like that?"

The woman's face appeared. "If you want it cooler, turn just that one." She pointed at the tap which had two knobs. One was marked with an "H" and the other with a "C".

"N-no. It's okay, I just…" What should she say? "I was just surprised. That's all."

"Shampoo and soap are on the shelf there. Do you need help with anything?"

"No, ma'am."

The hot water felt glorious. She used one of the smaller squares to scrub at her face and then the rest of her.

The soap and shampoo smelled like… well she wasn't sure what. Sweet and maybe plant-like?

She scrubbed the grit from her hair. From the other room she heard talking, but she couldn't make out the words. Then the

door opened again and Her Grace put another bundle on the counter.

"I guessed your size, but these are pretty forgiving. We can get something properly fitted later."

By the time Ariel was done, the water had turned gray and her fingers were wrinkled. Gingerly, she hauled herself upright. Somehow her side hurt more now than it had all day. She dried off and wrapped herself in a towel, checking in the mirror to see if she was actually clean.

Now that the soot was gone, her black eyes and cut lip were obvious. She'd be sore for a few days. The clothes Her Grace had brought were soft and new, catching on the rough skin of Ariel's hands. The shirt and drawstring trousers were only a little bit too big. The woman had even included thick socks that came up to her knees. Hurriedly she dressed, hoping that she wasn't in trouble for taking so long.

The woman sat in the other room in a chair at a small table. "I have tea and some scones. I fear the kitchen didn't understand what I was asking for."

The ration bars were cream colored with little flecks of red. They smelled unlike anything she'd ever experienced.

"Please come sit with me."

Hurriedly, Ariel crossed over to sit in the other chair. The woman placed one of the strange bars on a plate.

Unsure, Ariel picked it up. It was lighter than most ration bars and more crumbly. A tiny bite melted in her mouth. Sweeter than the baked apples even the slaves got once a year. She took a bigger bite.

Oh.

The first one disappeared in three bites.There was more on the big plate, but Ariel was reluctant to help herself. She didn't know how many were allowed.

Possibly sensing Ariel's concern, Her Grace put a different ration bar on her plate, "That's a meat pie," she said conversationally.

"You can have as many as you like, but I would like you to take your time. Okay?"

As many as she liked? What would that even mean? Taking her time made sense, though, Ariel had heard of people who got a hold of a crate of rations and eaten themselves sick.

The woman poured something into a cup and slid it across the table. "You should drink some of this."

As she picked up the cup Her Grace poured, Ariel's hands shook. Why was that? It didn't make any sense. With the utmost care, Ariel put the fragile cup back onto the table.

"Now, when you feel ready, you can tell me your name and anything else you might want me to know."

"My name's Ariel." A pause and then she added, "Your Grace."

"Hello, Ariel." The woman smiled. "I am very pleased to meet you." She shook her head dismissively. "You don't need to call me 'Your Grace.' It's true I am a duchess, but when I teach, I'm called Castaspella. In the classroom, I am a teacher, not a duchess."

"Yes, ma'am." Ariel looked down at her hands, twisting her fingers together. "What… what's going to happen to me?"

"That depends on what you want."

What she wanted? What did that even mean?

"Can you tell me how you came to be in the Whispering Woods?" The question was asked kindly, but Ariel wasn't sure how to

answer.

“I was on a work crew. Construction. One of the overseers… “ Quickly she flicked her eyes up, trying to gauge how the woman felt. “He… “ she choked on the sentence, not sure how to explain when she didn’t know what happened herself. “Had lightning? I guess he thought I was slacking or something. He tried to hurt me with it, and I don’t know what happened, but I threw it back in his face.”

The moment was a terrible bright flash in her mind. Slowly, without really paying attention, she stood. The food in her stomach turned to concrete as the terror of the last day struck with the force of the overseer’s lightning. Almost against her will, Ariel was on her feet and backing away until she backed into a wall. A sob rose from her throat. And then another.

“Dear one?”

The woman’s voice seemed to come from a long way off. Once again, there wasn’t enough air in this strange soft room. The window coverings made the walls feel closed in, but the ceiling was so high she felt like she’d fall *up.*

What was she doing here?

The woman stood up, too. “My dear, it’s all right.” Her eyes held Ariel’s as she moved very slowly toward her, making little “calm down”motions with one hand. “I imagine you’re feeling very frightened and very bewildered.”

She smiled gently and her dark eyes were kind. “I can see you’ve had a terrible time, I brought some potions for your injuries, and they will probably make you sleep.”

Sleep. Ariel desperately wanted to sleep. She nodded, trying to get a handle on her breathing.

The woman put one hand on Ariel’s shoulder and then her arms went around Ariel as the girl broke under the storm of feelings.

Ariel could not remember the last time someone held her when she cried and it seemed to fuel the sobs. The fabric of the woman's dress was getting wet and she tried to pull away, but the woman only rubbed Ariel's back.

"Shh. We can talk about the rest in the morning." Gently she led Ariel to sit down.

"Here." She handed Ariel the cup she'd poured. "Can you drink this? It's tea, with a potion for your injuries."

Even if she wanted to, Ariel couldn't refuse and she drank the odd-tasting brew in one gulp.

"Now, come and finish eating. And then bed. Everything else can wait."

Slowly, deliberately, Ariel ate the rest of the meat roll on her plate. When she finished, the woman led her to the soft oversized bunk and covered her up.

Under those warm, heavy blankets, the minute Ariel closed her eyes, she slid into sleep.

Castaspella's private study

High tower
Mystacor

Two years before Princess C'yara's abduction

For the next few days, the girl haunted Casta's apartment like a ghost, never speaking unless spoken to, taking nothing that was not given. She told them her name and that she had escaped from the Horde, but nothing else.

The healer pronounced the girl fit enough except for two cracked ribs and multiple soft tissue injuries in different phases of healing.

The scans found two old breaks in her bones, but nothing that had healed badly. She had not had any vaccinations, but her teeth were sound. The one useful feature of eating Horde ration bars was that they didn't have sugar.

After the healer's visit Casta had given her the run of the apartment. Wanting her to get comfortable before she took her to see the rest of Mystacor.

Casta was patient. This was not the first Horde refugee who had stumbled into Mystacor's wards and she would not be the last. The Woods had opinions about people's destinations.

The healer said the girl was between twelve and fourteen; older than Casta first presumed. Short and skinny, her hair lank, her cheeks pale, with the omnivorous nature of a child long-accustomed to hunger.

Although she had nearly set the woods on fire, she had zero knowledge of how magic worked. Her power seemed to have only recently revealed itself when she was under threat. It was likely that she'd shown it in the subtle ways children normally did, but her situation was so chaotic and magic so feared in the Horde, that neither she nor anyone around her had recognized it.

After what little surreptitious testing Casta had been able to do, she understood why the Woods had sent the child to her. The girl was a raw conduit of immense, instinctive power. Untrained, she was a danger.

To keep dark the mind of the sorcerer-born, that is a dangerous thing.

The translation from an Ancient's poem rang through Casta's mind. Fortunately, now that Ariel was here, Mystacor's wards and shields would contain any accidental magical explosions.

That gave them time for the girl to adjust. If she never wanted to be a sorcerer, they could teach her the bare minimum to keep herself safe.

“Your Grace?” Jerick peeked around the doorway of her office. “You should speak to our guest. I believe she is suffering from some misapprehension of her status.”

Raising one eyebrow at her seneschal, Casta turned to give him her whole attention. He was a man with infinite patience and thus had a knack for understatement. “Misapprehension?”

He sighed with a weary, fond expression she’d seen on him a hundred times. “She had a panic attack when the staff changed her bed. And then she asked when she was going to be assigned to a work crew.”

“Why did she have a panic attack?”

“Because they removed a small hoard of food from under it.”

“Oh. Poor thing!” Casta murmured, shaking her head at the contradiction. *So much power and the instincts of a starving squirrel.*

“I took everything that hadn’t spoiled and put it in the kitchen.” He shook his head sadly. “I do not think she believed me when I told her she was allowed to help herself.”

“Has she talked to you at all?” Jerick had dealt with other half-wild students. In the first few years of her appointment as Duchess, Castaspella had worked very hard to enable Mystacor to teach all who qualified. At that time, before he became her assistant, he had been in charge of the student’s quarters.

“Only to ask, very politely I must say, what her duties were and when she would be assigned to a work crew.”

“I would very much like to start her in some classes, but I fear we’ll probably have to start with the very basics.”

“Yes, Your Grace.”

“Where is she now?”

“She was in the library, but I believe she’s gone back to her room.”

Ariel’s room

High tower
Mystacor

Two years before Princess C’yara’s abduction

Ariel used the paper and pen she found on the desk to mark the time. A hatchmark for each day. She’d been here four days

Seven staff members that she'd seen. Two exits from this floor. Below her window, a courtyard where many people moved about. She catalogued it all, waiting to understand the pattern.

The rules in Mystacor made no sense. The sorceress, Castaspella, had allowed her to sleep in that big bed and had not assigned Ariel any work, or given her any orders at all. A healer had come to look at her and even that had not been nearly as horrible as Ariel feared.

It seemed that Castaspella was important. She said she was a “duchess” which Ariel assumed was some sort of commandant. The man, Jerick, he was the quartermaster? He had not assigned her any work either.

In fact, for the next couple of days, the only orders she had were from the healer. “Eat,” and “sleep.”

She’d done that. She’d been exhausted and *needed* sleep, but now she was getting bored.

This morning, three people came to her door in spotless uniforms. The older woman who seemed to be in charge said they were “housekeepers” there to clean.

“What should I do?” Ariel asked eagerly. Maybe if she volunteered to help them she could score a work assignment with them.

“Oh, don’t worry about anything,” the woman said cheerfully. “We won’t be a minute.”

Ariel retreated to the hallway, unsure what that meant. Uncertainly, she hovered outside the door, listening to them talk.

“Oh, look at this,” one sniffed. “This is going to attract pests.”

It sounded like they found the extra food she stashed under the bed. It wasn't her fault. They gave her a stupid amount of food, more than anyone could eat. Letting it rot made no sense. Wasting food was stupid. What else was she supposed to do? There was a meal in the morning, a meal at midday AND another meal in the evening with Casta in her special “eating room.”

“We’ll have to tell Jerick about it. He’ll know if Her Grace should be told.”

She braced herself against the wall in the hallway, shoulders hunched, listening to them talk and feeling sick. It didn’t matter if she was starving. If you took something without permission, it was theft. There were no excuses. Everybody knew that.

Maybe she was supposed to send what was uneaten back for someone else? That was an uncomfortable thought. Had she taken it out of some poor kid’s mouth?

The housekeepers apparently didn’t have the rank to discipline her. They would report her.

That was worse.

When Jerick found her that afternoon in the book room (she wasn't sure what it was called), she'd been braced for punishment, but he'd only apologized for having to throw out the pieces that had "spoiled."

He seemed way too worried about a tiny speck of green fuzz, if you asked her. They always just scraped it off back home. Then he told her that she was welcome to eat anything she found to her liking in the "kitchenette," the room where they stored the food.

The concept was so alien it made her head hurt. In her experience, gifts this large always had a hidden trigger. She just couldn't see where the pressure plate was.

When she asked if he could find her a job, something shifted in his expression. He'd gone careful, choosing his words, and told her to ask Castaspella. Then he said that he'd let Her Grace know she had questions. Like that was a good thing.

She took a long breath in as the fading lash marks on her back prickled and itched. She tried to tell herself that worrying was stupid.

Instead she opened the book she'd liberated from the book room.

She did not remember who taught her the letters. She felt like she always knew them. From knowing her letters, she had taught herself to read a little. If the words were simple.

"The Care and Feeding of Silverfins" she said out loud to herself. She did not sound out the letters so much as recognize the shape of the word.

Hopefully, no one would notice it was gone before she could put it back. That seemed likely. The room held an insane amount of books. Most of them were too thick, too heavy, too full of words she didn't know. But this one had a picture of a beautiful rainbow scaled fish. And when she opened it, she knew most of the words.

It was a manual of how to take care of the fish if you kept them as a pet.

Ariel knew people who kept rats or mice as pets, sharing bits of ration bars. Overseers usually killed them if they found out. But, fish? Who would keep fish? And how?

She sank into the chair, losing herself in the little universe of words where there was no room for fear.

Ariel's room

High tower
Mystacor

Two years before Princess C'yara's abduction

"Ariel?" Casta called as she knocked. "May I come in?"

"Yes?" A high pitched squeak answered. "Just-just a minute!"

Behind the door were the frantic furtive shuffling of someone hiding something. Perhaps she had retrieved some of her stash from the kitchen. Jerick was already arranging to make sure she had a food cupboard for her room so she wouldn't attract pests.

When Ariel opened the door, her too-bright eyes and flushed cheeks gave the definite impression that the girl felt caught. "I-I'm sorry, Your Grace."

"Please, you may call me Casta." She waved her hand dismissively. They'd get there eventually. "I thought we could have a talk about what you want to do next."

"Oh. Yes, ma'am."

“Come sit down, my dear.” She moved to the little table.

“I… Yes, ma’am.”

This child seemed to have very few words beyond “I’m sorry” and “Yes, ma’am.”

When Casta sat down, she felt something hard under the cushion, she reached down and pulled out a book from her own library. The cover had an illustration of one of the rainbow scaled magic fish that lived in the canals of the Starlight Courtyard, and was titled, *The Care and Feeding of Silverfins*.

Ariel’s hands jumped to cover her mouth and her eyes, impossibly, got even huger in her thin face. “I-I-I’m sorry! I found that room with all the books and… I wasn’t gonna steal it, I swear! I just… I wanted to look at it!”

But Casta only said gently, “Do you like books?”

Ariel blinked. “I… I don’t know how to read very good.” Her voice was barely a whisper. “I’ve never seen so many. I just… I wanted to see what it said.”

“Who taught you to read?” It was the most Ariel had said about herself and Casta hoped it would keep her talking.

“Nobody.” Twisting her hands together and biting her lip, Ariel looked on the verge of another panic attack. “I just… sometimes they leave manuals or reports lying around, so I look at them.

“You taught yourself?” Casta raised her eyebrows, genuinely impressed. “That’s remarkable, Ariel.”

The girl gave a half-shrug, arms hugging her thin frame.

Casta smiled and set the book down on the table. “Well, you’re in the right place for learning. And the books are here to read. You don’t have to ask permission. Just,please be careful with them. If there’s anything you want to learn, you only have to say so.”

Ariel's eyes darted between the book and Casta's face. "Really?"

"Never be ashamed of your curiosity. It's a gift." She beckoned the girl over and Ariel came to sit down almost reluctantly. Casta handed her the book back. "Why did you choose that one?"

"It… a lot of the words are ones I already know. And I like animals." She took the book and put it on her lap.

"A very appropriate selection then." The book was aimed at readers a little younger than Ariel, but the subject matter would not strike the girl as childish. "Would you like to see a Silverfin?"

"See them?" The girl's eyes lit up. "I'd love that!"

Casta grinned at the first sign of childlike behavior from the girl. "I'll take you after supper, if you want. Before we do that I'd like to talk to you about what happens now."

She sat back in her chair, and the girl instantly tensed, studying Casta's face and glancing at her hands. An unconscious check in. Monitoring the emotional state of the authority in the room. Casta made sure to adopt an open posture.

"Jerick mentioned that you have been asking about when you'll be assigned to a work crew?"

Ariel nodded. "Yes, ma'am. Your Grace. I was hoping I could maybe get assigned to help here?" She twisted her hands in her lap.

"Thank you for the thought, dear one. But, I should tell you that Mystacor only employs staff after they turn eighteen."

"Oh." The girl's head dropped so that she looked down at her twisting fingers and she sniffed.

Casta hurried on, not able to bear the look of profound disappointment at being denied a job as a maid. "But I understand you'd like to stay here?"

Another jerky shrug, as though she was not sure what the safest answer was.

"*I* would very much like you to stay." Hopefully, the girl would hear reassurance rather than pressure.

The girl's head snapped up. "Here? I can stay? But… " She looked around the room. "I don't understand, you just said…"

"Yes, I know. But, I didn't want to offer you a job as a maid."

Enormous green eyes locked onto Casta's.

"I wanted to offer you a place as my apprentice."

Freckles stood out starkly as Ariel paled, her skin turning the color of sour milk. "Your… apprentice?" she echoed.

The poor child was already scared out of her mind. But really, they had no choice. Casta wanted so badly to reach out and hug the girl again, but it was too soon for that sort of gesture. That first night, Ariel had reached out to her in an extremis of fear and exhaustion, not trust. Trust only built over time.

Instead, she stuck to the facts. "Magic as strong as yours is dangerous if you don't learn to use it. At the very least you need to learn some control."

"Th-they were going to send me to the Dark Temple. To Shadow Weaver."

"Is that what made you run away?"

The girl blinked rapidly and looked away. "Yeah." She paused and her breathing hitched. Her shoulders jumped, a jerky self-conscious movement, and she rubbed her nose with the palm of her hand. "Sort of."

"Ariel." Casta caught and held the girl's eyes, *willing* her to believe. "I'm glad you escaped her."

“I don’t want to be like that.” She hunched over, hugging herself, making herself even smaller, as though she wanted to disappear.

“Like what?”

“They use magic to hurt people.”

The sorceress nodded. She knew very well what Shadow Weaver’s minions were taught. She had regularly fought those forces.

And of course Ariel had heard terrible things about Mystacor. The Horde forces called Casta “The Mad Duchess.”

With good reason. Casta *had* gone a little mad after Micah’s death. When the Princess Alliance broke. When Angella had collapsed on herself and retreated to Bright Moon to mourn, Casta had been the one to continue the fight. She led combat sorcerers across the border for months, leaving every opponent who survived the encounter to limp home, charred and bloodied, to carry the tale.

To make the Horde understand what Mystacor’s people (and Mystacor’s leaders) were capable of.

Ariel wouldn’t know the difference between the Dark Temple’s magic and the fire Casta had rained down on the border in those months after Micah’s death. To her, it would all blur together. To a child who'd only ever seen power used as a whip, what difference did it make who held it?

“Ariel. I’m not sure if you can believe this yet, but magic is so much more than that. Magic can be beautiful. It can heal as well as harm.”

The girl looked at the book in her lap, her fingers tracing the embossed picture of a silverfin. “Why do you keep these fish?” she asked.

The non-sequitor startled Casta a little. A strange question, but

the girl seemed to be thinking hard about something.

“Mostly because they’ve been here as long as Mystacor has existed. They are intelligent. Some say they were even kept as familiars by some sorcerers.”

“But, you feed them? And take care of them?” Her head came up again. “The book makes it sound complicated.”

“Well, yes, but… “

“They’re not there to be sacrifices? Or food? Or anything?”

“No. Mostly, we keep them because they are beautiful.” Suddenly, Casta understood the test the girl was setting before her. Ariel was asking whether she had to earn her right to survive. “And they are part of our community. We take care of the people and creatures who live here. It’s a sacred trust.”

“This manual says that no one’s allowed to hurt them. And that they’re fed every day. There’s even a section that talks about what to do if they get sick.”

“Yes. I can show you.”

“What do I have to do?” The girl straightened up and her chin firmed. She clenched her fists on her knees. Perhaps the idea that the fish were well cared for made Ariel able to trust, just a little. “If I were to become your apprentice?”

“I think I would like to give you some basic lessons myself before I enroll you in classes. We can figure out where you are in your reading and writing, and then…"

Ariel shifted nervously and bit her lip, questions behind her eyes.

“Yes, dear?”

“Is it true they train combat sorcerers here?” she looked down at her hands, fisted in her lap on top of the book. “To fight the

Horde?”

“Yes, we do.” And, if Ariel wasn’t comfortable being educated in a place that held such fear, Mystacor wasn’t the only place in the world to learn sorcery. Casta could consult with some of her colleagues to see who might be available to mentor the girl. “Of course that’s not something you have to learn if you don’t want to.”

“They hurt me because I couldn’t fight back. They kill anything that’s beautiful.” Ariel looked up, her jaw too hard for such a round face, green eyes glinting. “Teach me. I want to learn how to fight them.”

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